

A FREE ENCOUNTER · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

THE MERCY HIVES

Her honey cures anything. It is pressed from the town's dead, and every jar costs you a memory of someone you loved.

An encounter for four characters · levels 3–5 · 5e-compatible (SRD 5.1)

THE SETUP

The Corrigan apiary stands off the Threshing Cross road, thirty white hives in rows behind a hedge of flowering thyme. People walk out from the village sick and walk home well, carrying a small clay jar. Nobody in Threshing Cross has buried a neighbor badly in two years. They also cannot quite tell you what the dead looked like.

READ ALOUD

Thirty white boxes stand in the dusk, humming so low you feel it in your teeth before you hear it. The bees are still working after dark. A woman in a veiled hat moves among the hives without a lantern, sure of every step. On a plank table by the gate sit rows of small clay jars, each stoppered with wax and marked with one pressed flower. The hum is not quite a single note. Stand still and it climbs and falls like voices in the next room, too far to make out the words.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON (GM)

Hettie Corrigan kept bees with her husband Redmond for thirty years. When Redmond died, she could not stand the quiet, so she did a thing a hedge-witch grandmother had once warned her never to do: she gave the hive his name to keep, and the bees kept it. His voice is still in the low hum if you listen. That was the whole of it, at first. One grieving woman and a hive that remembered one man.

Then the summer fever came through Threshing Cross and started taking children. Hettie found that honey pressed from the remembering comb heals: it closes wounds, breaks fevers, mends what medicine cannot. It heals because the hive runs on remembrance, and a jar takes as much as it gives. Whoever eats the mercy honey loses their clearest memory of someone they have lost. The fever broke. The graveyard filled and then went quiet, and the village slowly stopped being able to picture the people under the stones.

Hettie knows the cost. She tells herself it is mercy, because a forgotten grief is lighter than a dead child, and because she cannot stop: stopping means the sick die, and it means Redmond dies the rest of the way, and she is already forgetting him one jar at a time to keep everyone else well.

PLAY HER AS A WOMAN WHO IS SURE SHE IS RIGHT

Hettie is not a sorcerer and not a monster. She is a widow who found a terrible answer to a real problem and cannot let herself see it as terrible, because then Redmond is only dead and the children she saved were saved by a curse. Lay out her logic plainly. Let it almost hold. Let the players feel the moment it stops. Run her as a confession, not a fight. The bees only rise if someone goes for the hives.

The binding lives in one hive, the tallest, at the center: the royal comb, where Redmond's name is kept. Burn that comb or free the name it holds and the mercy ends. Hettie guards it with her body, the way you would guard the last of someone.

MORE TO PAINT

Use these when the party reaches the gate and when they open or threaten the center hive.

The buyer at the gate. A village man named Garret Nolde is here ahead of the party, hat in his hands, a jar already paid for. His daughter Wren has the fever bad tonight. Use this beat to make the cost a face, not an idea: the honey works, and Garret will pay it, and he does not know yet what paying looks like from the inside.

READ ALOUD

The man at the table turns the little jar over and over in his hands like it might change its mind. "Third night she's burned," he says, to nobody. "The woman says one spoonful and she'll sit up by morning. Says it so plain." He looks at the veiled woman among the hives, then back at the jar. "You'd give anything, wouldn't you. You'd give anything and call it cheap."

The royal comb, up close. GM: this is the reveal. Do not read the box below until the party opens or threatens the center hive. The humming voice is Redmond. Once they hear their own longing in it, the choice stops being abstract.

READ ALOUD

The center hive is taller than the rest and warm to the touch, warmer than bees alone could make it. When the lid lifts, the hum resolves for one moment into something almost like a word, and the word is a name. Not a name you know. But said the way you would say the name of the person you would give anything to hear once more, in a voice that has been saying it for two years and cannot stop.

THE INTERESTING CHOICE

The party can burn the apiary in ten minutes. The bees are not the threat and Hettie will not be one. The threat is the arithmetic she is standing inside, and the fact that she is right that people will die without her.

There are three doors, and none of them is clean:

- **Buy the mercy.** Wren Nolde lives tonight, and someone pays: Garret forgets his late wife, or a party member who takes the jar loses their clearest memory of someone they lost. The honey works exactly as promised. That is the horror of it.
- **End it.** Free the royal comb and the mercy stops for good. Threshing Cross keeps its dead in memory again and starts burying its sick again. Wren may be the first.
- **Turn Hettie.** The richest path: convince Hettie to let Redmond go herself, and to face the village with the truth instead of the honey, so the town chooses its cure with open eyes. This is a confession earned, not a lock picked.

MECHANICS

- **The Mourning Swarm (3, scalable):** use the SRD *swarm of insects* stat block, reflavored as the hive roused to defend the royal comb. They rise *only* if someone attacks Hettie or the hives, and do not pursue past the thyme hedge. **Encounter math:** three swarms (CR 1/2, 100 XP each) = 300 XP, adjusted **600** by the tool, a **Medium** fight for four 3rd-level characters (thresholds 300 / 600 / 900 / 1,600). The swarm is a warning, not a war: the encounter breaks the moment it becomes a boss fight instead of a reckoning.
- **Hettie Corrigan:** SRD *commoner* with Insight and Persuasion at +5. She is not a combatant and will not become one. She will beg, explain, bargain, and finally put herself between the party and the center hive.
- **Read the widow (Wisdom / Insight, DC 13):** on a success the party sees grief, not witchcraft, before they draw steel. Failure costs nothing but the benefit of the doubt: she reads as a hedge-witch running a charnel apiary, and the scene tips toward the torch.
- **Learn the cost (Intelligence / Investigation or Arcana, DC 15):** working through the jars, the empty graves, and the humming reveals what the honey takes and that the tallest hive holds a bound name. Fail-forward: they get half of it (the honey takes *something*) and learn the rest the hard way, by watching Garret not recognize his own wife's grave on the walk home.

- **Turn her (skill challenge, three successes before two failures, all DC 15):** Charisma (Persuasion) to reach the grief under the arithmetic, Charisma (Intimidation) to make her look at what she has done to the graveyard, or Wisdom (Insight) to name the one thing she cannot say aloud, that she is forgetting Redmond to save strangers. On success she lifts the royal lid herself. Fail-forward: she refuses and throws herself across the center hive, and now the only off-switch left is fire.

OUTCOMES

- **Buy the mercy** → Wren sits up by morning. Garret walks home lighter and cannot say why, and stops at a grave he does not recognize. The party has seen the price paid on a real face. A callback for later.
- **Burn the royal comb** → the hum stops mid-word. Hettie folds up beside the dead hive with nothing left to be right about, and Threshing Cross wakes tomorrow to a fever it has to fight the old way, and to a graveyard it can suddenly remember.
- **Turn Hettie** → she reads Redmond his release, the mercy ends by her own hand, and she becomes the woman who has to tell the village what she did and help them bury the next one honestly. She may follow the party as a healer who never touches a shortcut again.
- **Kill Hettie** → the binding is orphaned, the hives go feral and quiet in a week, and two years of borrowed forgetting come back at once: a whole village grieving people they only just remembered they lost. A hook for next week.

SCALING

- **3rd level:** three Mourning Swarms as written; lean on the choice and the humming, not the damage.
- **Levels 1–2:** one or two swarms; the fight is a warning shot, not a war. Two swarms is an *Easy* fight for four 2nd-level characters (adjusted 300).
- **Levels 4–5:** four or five swarms, and let the royal comb itself rise as a single larger swarm (double HP) when the center hive is struck. Swarms scale slowly, so keep the pressure on the clock of Wren's fever, not the hit points.
- **Larger party:** add swarms, never make Hettie a fight. The encounter is a reckoning with a grieving woman. It breaks the instant she becomes a monster to be put down.

WHAT THE COMB REMEMBERS (D8)

Roll or pick what a listener hears in the royal hive's hum. Each is a memory the town has already sold for honey, offered as a hook a DM can grow into its own trouble.

d8	The comb remembers
1	A lullaby in a dead language, hummed by a grandmother nobody at the table can name anymore.
2	The exact weight of a child who has a headstone but no face left in any living mind.
3	A wedding vow, spoken by a widower who bought honey for his cough last spring and now wonders why he never remarried.
4	The name of the man who dug every grave in Threshing Cross, forgotten by the town he served.
5	An argument, unfinished, that both people would give anything to finish, and one of them is in the ground.
6	The smell of a bakery that closed when its baker died, kept alive only in the hive.
7	A debt of kindness owed to someone the debtor can no longer picture, so it will never be repaid.
8	Your own name, said back to you in a voice you almost recognize, if you have taken the honey before.



IF A GRIEVER WHO FOUND A TERRIBLE MERCY IS YOUR KIND OF VILLAIN

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